

During the 20th century, there were three key figures – Carl Schmitt, Walter Benjamin, and Jacob Taubes – who offered contrasting yet interconnected approaches to political theology. All three individuals examined how religion shaped political discourse, but each ideology had different conclusions. It is important to note how Schmitt uses theology to legitimize the state's total authority, while Taubes and Benjamin offered a different perspective on the state of the political. The contrasting ideologies of this relationship between the political and theology are better explained when comparing each form of thought with one another.

Schmitt's state of exception is used when society is in danger, specifically when the varying construction of law is in danger. It is a systematic attack against a country or a body of government, which can be also referred to as an attack on societal norms. The state of exception is declared by whoever maintains power within a political body. However, this declaration of power declared by an individual who maintains sole power is dangerous because it is subjective. To further expand on Schmitt's state of exception, it can be best described as the void that funnels down from the laws that maintain society. This "void" is the state of exception or the necessary action that must be taken to assert power. Schmitt uses the "void" behind his reasoning as to why it is necessary to reach this state of power and justifies the following rationale that he believes to explain political theology.

Schmitt's analogy between the state of exception and the theological notion of the miracle is underscored by the rendition of the bible. If laws are defined by physics, the leader is defined by God, then the suspension of laws must be defined as a miracle. In terms of theology, Christ is an example of an exception outside the norm, in which he defies the odds. Thus, Christ

is an exception outside the norm which legitimizes the excessive political power that leaders gain under Schmitt's construction of political theology. Similar to how miracles disrupt the natural course of laws, allowing for divine intervention, the state of exception disrupts the ordinary norms and societal order, enabling sovereign intervention by the government. Both examples exemplify heightened authoritative responses to extraordinary circumstances.

Schmitt's reasoning for the state of exception and the dichotomy of friend vs. enemy is supported by the condition of the possibility of the transcendental. It is this mindset that Schmitt reinforces to maintain political power within a government. Any person or people that has the potential or possibility to kill or attack Schmitt's ideology can be described as an enemy politically. However, Schmitt emphasizes that it is important to maintain this relationship while in power because the distinction between enemy and friend must be defined, or else it will not exist. Simply, if there are no enemies then there can be no difference in friends. Enemies are needed to define friends and vice versa. The relationship between enemy and friend is underscored by the complete separation between the two groups. Schmitt relates the political to annihilation, by which one needs opposition to define oneself. There cannot be a state of power without an enemy. A flaw within Schmitt's friend vs. enemy dichotomy is when the enemy is on the same side as the friend, referred to as a terrorist, in which this group breaks the friend vs. enemy dynamic and breaks the rules. The relationship is possible because the dichotomy can bring people together and diverge people. In Schmitt's political theological perspective, the friend vs. enemy dichotomy.

When comparing Schmitt's ideology to Taubes, Schmitt emphasizes the distinction between the friend vs. enemy dichotomy bolstering the political framework and in turn peace in

society. Taubes states that if one understands the political structure, then at some point the political will remove itself and render itself useless. Taubes defines history as finite, in which at some point there is no time, and history is finished. If people understand political theology correctly then there is no reason to preserve the dichotomy between friend vs. enemy, thus the political should not be preserved. Taubes believes that the world can continue without the political. To further explain the difference between Schmitt and Taubes, Schmitt promotes a strong state of power is justified by theological concepts while Taubes uses political theology as a method to challenge existing authoritative figures in a future that transcends them. A similarity between Schmitt and Taubes is their understanding of politics requires one to understand theology. However, there are two key differences between the two ideologies, Taubes believes that theology does not need to be reinforced between politics, whereas Schmitt believes that theology needs to be constantly supported by the political. Additionally, Taubes believes that the political does not need to affirm itself and will make itself dispensable, while Schmitt believes that there needs to be constant affirmation from a position of power. Taubes's reasoning as to why the political can render itself useless is due to his interpretation of theology as it is like a "thief in the night" (Thessalonians, New Testament). Meaning, that Christ will be back when the world will be a mess, thus encouraging people to never be sinful because people will never realize when he will come back. Taubes claims that Schmitt is mischaracterizing political power. To understand Taubes, it is imperative to understand Benjamin as most of Taubes ideology builds from the foundation that Benjamin set up.

Furthermore, the distinction between Schmitt's ideology of political theology and Benjamin's is exemplified through the importance of eschatology and history. Schmitt focuses on permanent, concentrated power, while Benjamin's perception of sovereignty is temporary,

and withers away in a future utopia. Schmitt requires the state of the exception and violence to maintain order; however, Benjamin requires a necessary evil for liberation. Benjamin's critical theory is based on historical context, in which to understand the form of life, one should look back on the history of this form of life. If at some point in time, the political renders itself useless, then history has been made. To further elaborate, there needs to be a pre and post such that things don't happen conceptually, they happen in time. On the contrary, Schmitt's ideas are static and show a blind spot in his political theology. Moreover, Schmitt's static ideas of political power fail to account for the nature of history and the evolving issues of society. Contrastingly, Benjamin provides an approach that acknowledges the change in power dynamics and potential historical and revolutionary change. Benjamin highlights the interconnectedness of the past, present, and future, viewing history as a platform of ongoing struggle and transformation. By associating the political with historical context, Benjamin offers a clearer understanding of political relationships and societal change. While Schmitt's political theology may provide a framework for authority to maintain stability, Benjamin provides a better understanding of temporary political power and offers a clearer perspective on the possibility of free politics.

By acknowledging the importance of the contrasting ideologies of political theology, it can be further developed in light of negative theology. Negative theology was coined by Simon Hewitt who mentions that he is mentally ill and sympathetic to people in pain, specifically human pain, and certain type of theology. The use of political theology is underscored by the unknown of God, reinforcing political theology's purpose. God can be compared to a Black Knight, who masks his or her identity and his significance. Knowing something is knowing what a variable is, thus in terms of God, one cannot say anything about God that is positive when there is room for the negative. Negative theology is built on the premise that no things can be claimed

about God, therefore negative statements can be discussed about God. The argument of negative theology is that one can make a positive statement about God that is difficult to justify, “I do not know God’s properties,” while one can make an assertive negative statement about God that can be justified, “I know that God is not a table.” While Schmitt, Taubes, Benjamin, and the Theology of Liberation share that they must think and say things about God. However, Hewitt argues how can one say things about God when there is no definitive description of God. Hewitt claims that there can’t be a definition of God if one cannot say anything about God, then they cannot say anything positive about God and can only say negative attributes which leads to a paradox.

Hewitt focuses on the descriptive notions that individuals perceive God, such as “God, my father, God is P (loving, kind, good, etc....), God is good, and God is not bad” (New and Old Testament). Hewitt believes that his argument has value and poses a potential problem when talking about God. One issues he proposes is that the experience of God is a mystical experience in which it is so overwhelming that one cannot describe it. Therefore, nothing can be said about God, and if it were to be true then that statement must be false because it is too overwhelming. This relationship between what is true and false further emphasize the paradoxical connection individuals have with God, highlighting the principle of non-contradiction. To expand on the paradox between true and false in regard to God, if a sentence about God is true then it is false, and if a sentence about God is false then it is true. In terms of apophatic theology, it is imperative to tweak the theology in order to make it logical, thus classical logic must be rendered useless and para-consistent logic is necessary. This relationship demonstrates the bivalent logics (PAFP), in which every proposition or statement can be judged as true or false but cannot be both. Therefore, dialectism helps preserve apophatism because it helps maintain the mysticism of God

and unfathomable to describe and encourage individuals to debate two truths rather than settle on one.

Leben's solution is an alternative solution to dialectism, which helps better understand mysticism. PAIP causes a problem if it is true and if no contradiction can be true then it must be false. An important question to ask in regard to Leben's solution is: if mysticism is false then why should anyone care if it's not true. Leben's solution, ineffable knowledge of God, restricts the falsification and save from the question approach to the problem in the first place, reflecting classical logic. The contradictory knowledge of God between true and false statements that are both correct can be classified as a dialetheic solution. The overlap of theologies is the breaking point to one another in which individuals can have contradictory true statements.

While Schmitt, Taubes, and Benjamin all understand the interplay of sovereignty and political order, their approach to political theology differs. Schmitt encourages a singular sovereign, who embodies the exception and transcends political structures. Taubes, on the other hand, emphasizes that understanding the political leads itself useless, encouraging for a future with transcending political authority within the finite nature of history and challenging existing authoritative figures. Benjamin's ideology centers around viewing political power as transient and ultimately fade into a future "utopia," enforced by a necessary evil for liberation and emphasizing the value of historical context to understand political dynamics and revolutionary change. By comparing the three philosophers, one can better understand the intricate ways in which political theology and their contrasting ideologies have influenced new foundations on political authority.

In conclusion, when comparing political theology in light of negative theology and the contrasting ideologies discussed, one can better understand the importance between their differences. Schmitt, Taubes, and Benjamin provide a monotheistic perspective on political theology, yet differ in which power is maintained. For Schmitt God is the most powerful expression of power and is the most important entity, while Taubes and Benjamin believe when power is at its top it will remove itself in which god cares about humans and shapes history that influences people's actions. On the other hand, theology of liberations and apophatic theology focus more on Christianity in which God, or Jesus, is suffering with us thus he cannot feel sympathy. From apophatic theology's perspective God is so potent and transcendent that nothing can be said about God. Between each thought of political theologies, the thickness and understanding of God varies with Schmitt being the most straight forward building up to Benjamin/Taubes, then the Theologies of Liberation, and finally with negative theology being the most complex or thick. Negative theology can be approached to each thought of political theology. The purpose of comparing these various political ideologies is to better understand how political bodies make decision based on theology rather than diplomatic opinions.